A Door Near Here

By Heather Quarles

(pg 9-12) Careful not to step on any of the empty bottles near my feet, I reached out to push her shoulder again, but she slapped my hand away with a force that encouraged me. I wondered if maybe she was starting to get better. A little bit of her hair was sticking out from the top of the quilt - blond and wavy like Tracy's - and if I only looked at that part of the picture, I could almost pretend she was fine. Just taking a nap or something.

"Mom, do you know where the main water valve is? Douglas is trying to fix the sink."

"Go away, I'm sick." I couldn't stand to look at her swollen eyes, so I concentrated only on her hair, which was golden. Perfectly golden, like it always had been… for years and years, before her face had changed.

"The main valve, Mom. The main water valve? Where is it - in the basement?"

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"In the base… ment? What are you talking about? Ask your ***father*** where it is - he's the one who wanted the stupid… house." She lifted the bottle of sherry and emptied the contents into the glass, sending it spinning in crazy circles on its base. She watched until it stopped teetering, then she gave a strange giggle and let the bottle fall to the carpet.

"Mom, Dad lives in Michigan. He left 10 ***years*** ago."

"Well, tell me something I don't already know. You little brat."

Right then Douglas stuck his head in the door. "Katherine *(whispering)*, we found it. It's fixed. It's off."

I backed toward the door, keeping my eyes on my mother. "Ok. Sorry, we found it, Mom, you can go back to sleep."

"You kids get out of my bed, my . . . room. My ***God***, can't you even let me rest in peace? *Just go away!*"

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INTRODUCTION

Everyone dreams of having the "perfect family" -- with siblings (brothers and sisters) you can count on, lovable grandparents, and understanding parents. Even though some families are filled with weird and wacky relatives, you grow up loving them anyway.

Of course, there are the "broken families." In this selection, the mother of four children grows to become an alcoholic after she gets divorced and loses her job. It is up to Katherine, the eldest, to keep her family alive in A Door Near Here by Heather Quarles.

(Pg 19-20) See, this wasn't the first time my mom had gone on a drinking-sleeping binge for a bunch of days in a row. It was just the longest - because before, she'd always had a job to worry about. And even when Mom ***was*** up and sober, she was practically never around.

Even though she earned money, Mom herself was always saying that if it wasn't for Dad's child-support checks we'd all go down the tubes. That fact really pissed her off, which is why she worked so many hours to try to get promoted, and why it especially sucked when she got fired by her boss "for having one lousy beer on the job." That was all she talked about for the

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rest of the summer, which was extremely annoying. She bought a ton of new clothes, went around job hunting, got all these rejection letters. Then, finally one day in September, she just climbed into bed with her sherry and told us she wouldn't take any phone calls.

My mom is an alcoholic, in case you haven't figured that out by now. She has all the signs. I've read a million magazine articles on the subject, so when she started drinking so much and missing work, I knew what was going on and I explained the whole thing to Douglas and Tracey. It didn't take a rocket scientist to figure it out. But Alisa didn't know - she just thought our mom was sick.

(Pg 24-25) I was five years old the day my dad left my mother and took off to live with Ophelia in Michigan. I only knew who Ophelia was because she used to sit at the front desk of my dad's dental practice, and she gave me purple toothbrushes when I went in for check-ups.

My dad took Douglas, Tracey, and I all out to dinner and when we finished eating, he told us he was

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moving far away with Ophelia - not because he didn't love ***us***, but because he loved ***her*** so much more than Mommy. Then he drove us back to the house, dropped us off on the front steps, and we didn't hear from him again for three years - when he mailed us an invitation to his and Ophelia's wedding.

My mom yelled and swore and drank for three weeks straight after that. I still remember it. It was the first time I ever saw her drunk. Even though I didn't know what drunk was at the time, I knew something was different. She started serving popcorn for dinner every night, for one thing. While we ate our popcorn, she'd tell us what a dirt-eating worm our father was, and drink sherry and cry. I kept thinking I would cry too, but instead I just kept getting that headache behind my eyes. And ever since then, for almost ten years, I have never cried again for any reason. I'm not sure whether that should worry me or not.

(Pg 16) Two years after my parents got divorced, Alisa was born. I have no idea who Alisa's biological father is – I don't think my mother even knows. **(Pg 41)**

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My mom had a million boyfriends. Strictly speaking, I guess Alisa was only our half sister. But she'd always seemed ***more*** related, not less. We all remembered the day she'd come home from the hospital, looking like a shriveled-up raisin in a yellow blanket. We'd been in love with her from that day on.

(Pg 1) Alisa [is] in third grade and **(Pg 17)** is crazy about C.S. Lewis – [you know] The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe. **(Pg 1)** [She] handed me the letter:

(Pg 18) Dear CS, I like your books about Narnia. I can tell you did not make them up because no one could make up espeshially about Aslan, so I know they are true. I was wondering if you could tell me where a secret door is from here to Narnia. I need to go to Narnia very bad, I think someone there can help my mom, she is sick. Love, Alisa Donavan

(Pg 21) I decided Tracey, Douglas and I should have a meeting. We needed a more organized way to deal with Alisa and Mom – and life in general.

(Pg 34) After school, we had our first official "family meeting in the treehouse.

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(Pg 37) KATHERINE: "I think we should really talk about how we're running things. The situation with the house and food and Alisa – especially money and food. Well?"

DOUGLAS: "Well, what?"

KATHERINE: "What do you ***think***?"

DOUGLAS: "What do we think of what?"

TRACEY: "She means about ***Mom***, Douglas. What are we going to do about Mom?"

(pg 39) KATHERINE: "We need a plan for what to do about *us* - and Alisa – Especially Alisa. She's getting totally neglected. We need to figure out a way to keep things normal while Mom's in bed. We should eat together and have clean laundry, you know? **(Pg 37)** What I'm talking about are goals. Establishing the means and ends to a plan of *survival*."

(Pg 38) TRACEY: "We're running out of food. The house is a sty. You're the only one who works, Douglas, and you don't make that much from a paper route once a week. Mommy's probably not going to ever get up, she's

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probably going to ***die*** up there, and what Katherine means is what the hell are we going to do?"

(Pg 39) KATHERINE: "I made a list of ideas --"

DOUGLAS: "You're not going to try to get the sherry away from her again, are you?

KATHERINE: Calm down, Douglas. I don't think we can do anything about Mom. As long as she keeps eating, at least a little bit, she's not going to die. People don't die from being alcoholic, except after a long time like twenty years.

(Pg 40) DOUGLAS: Maybe we should just call Dad."

TRACEY: "We can't."

DOUGLAS: "Why not? Just because you guys hate him."

TRACEY: "If Dad found out Mom's been drunk for this long, he'd make us go stay with him and Ophelia in Michigan -- and then what would happen to Alisa?"

(Pg 42) DOUGLAS: "Ok, you're right. We can't tell Dad."

TRACEY: "We can't tell any teachers either. They'll report Mom to Social Services and we'll get stuck in foster homes.

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(pg 43) KATHERINE: "It probably won't come to that. If we're smart about how we act right now, it won't come to that."

(pg 45) In the end I wrote down conclusions in my notebook: 1. Tree house meetings will now be daily. 2. Current assets: $33.25. 3. Don't tell ANYONE about Mom. And 4. Don't act suspicious.

(Pg 44) I believed we could handle anything. Even if Mom never got back up. I thought we could keep everybody safe. Which just goes to show how stupid you can be when you're fifteen. Even if you're smart.

(Pg 230) My mother didn't stop drinking until they actually took her to the hospital. Ms. Haley [Alisa's teacher] took her, and the only reason Mom agreed to go was because she was still drunk and she wanted Ms. Haley to leave her alone. As far as I know, she hasn't gotten any less depressed and it's been eight months.

(Pg 223) We live in Grand Rapids now, with my father and Ophelia. All of us, including Alisa.

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(Pg 230-231) [The other day], Alisa sat down under the tree house where there was a patch of shade. I sat down beside Alisa and we looked back at the house.

ALISA: "Katherine, you still don't believe in Narnia, do you?"

KATHERINE: "No."

ALISA: "Do you believe in God?"

I looked up through the tree branches to the sky. "I don't know."

ALISA: "I do. ***I*** believe in God."

KATHERINE: "Well, you believe in ***everything***."

Right at that moment, looking at Alisa's suntanned face, I felt practically joyful. I'm not sure why, even, but I was happier than I had been in a long time.

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AWARD HISTORY

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